

REDMOND

Software has left the dev team

What is already happening, and what we are doing about it.

September 2026

THE WHY

This is not something coming. It already happened.

People across Redmond are building working software today — without the development team, without a budget line, and in many cases without telling anyone. AI removed the hard part of getting started.

Software has left the dev team

WHAT WE FOUND

We thought there were ten or twenty

122

apps, integrations, APIs and
services on the register today

13

of those are truly mission critical —
the rest are not

1

development team, which did not
build most of them

Most of these are useful. The people who built them solved a real problem faster than we could have. The gap was that we had no way of knowing what existed, what it touched, or who fixes it when it breaks.

WHAT IT MEANS

Two things are true at once

Freedom is the point

People should be able to try things without asking permission. That is how most of these got built, and we do not want to slow it down.

Some of it has to be dependable

When something breaks at two in the morning and the company runs on it, somebody has to be on the hook. That cannot be one person and a side project.

So the question is not whether people should build. They already are. The question is how we tell these two apart — without putting a gate in front of everything.

THE ANSWER

Three lanes

LANE 1

Explore

Try anything. Personal tools, experiments, throwaway ideas. Nothing touches company data.

Register: nothing

Support: none, it is yours

Who builds: anyone

LANE 2

Paved road

Real tools other people use. Touches company data, so it goes on the register and uses the standard setup.

Register: yes

Support: you support your app, IT and data support the environment

Who builds: anyone

LANE 3

Engineered

The systems the company runs on. Built and supported to a standard, with someone accountable around the clock.

Register: yes

Support: dev team, under an SLA

Who builds: dev team

HOW A LANE GETS PICKED

The lane is decided by what the app touches

Not by who built it. Not by how important it feels. If it touches company data, it goes on the register. If the company depends on it, it gets engineered.

An app can move up a lane when it earns it — with a conversation attached, not as a surprise.

WHAT THIS PROTECTS

Most of Redmond never notices any of this

- No approval queue to try something. Lane 1 registers nothing and asks no one.
- The rules land only where the risk is — company data, and systems we depend on.
- People keep building. We stop being surprised by what they built.
- When something matters enough to be supported properly, there is a path to that instead of a rebuild.
- Lane 2 is deliberately broad — a tool for twenty people and a tool for two hundred both belong there.

WHO DECIDES

Tech Team Coordination

A standing group drawn from teams that already exist: IT, data, development, the app team, and projects. It meets weekly and has been meeting since August.

Not a new department. Not a headcount ask. It sets direction — it does not operate anything.

HOW IT WORKS

It sets the standard. The teams do the work.

Sets the direction	Runs it day to day
What counts as sensitive data	Data team
Access, identity and roles	IT team
The register and what stays on it	Development team
Approved tools and third-party apps	App team
Development standards and review	Development team

If this group started operating things, every access request in the company would wait on a weekly meeting. That is the friction we are removing, not adding.

WHERE WE WOULD LIKE YOUR HELP

Three things

- Your read on the model — three lanes, freedom by default, structure only where it is earned. Tell us what we missed.
- Help getting the word out, so people building know the path exists and know who to talk to.
- Working through the open piece with us: who picks up a Lane 2 app when the person who built it cannot.

The register is live. The lane model is documented. The group is meeting weekly. Development standards come after those two are settled — deliberately last.